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Author(s): WIEBREN J. BOONSTRA and SOFIE JOOSSE

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The Social Dynamics of Degrowth

WIEBREN J. BOONSTRA*

*Stockholm Resilience Centre/Baltic Nest Institute
Stockholm University
P.O. Box 1096, Stockholm, Sweden
Email: wijnand.boonstra@stockholmresilience.su.se
* Corresponding author*

SOFIE JOOSSE

*Department of Social and Economic Geography
Uppsala University
P.O. Box 513, Uppsala, Sweden
Email: sofie.joosse@kultgeog.uu.se*

ABSTRACT

Degrowth cannot be realised from within a capitalist society, since growth is the sine qua non for capitalism. But, societies are no blank slates; they are not built from scratch. Putting these two thoughts together seems to make degrowth logically impossible. In this paper we argue that this paradox can be solved with the use of classical and contemporary concepts from the social sciences. We illustrate the use of these concepts with reference to studies on current practices and patterns of food production and consumption. The concept of social mechanism is used to illustrate how social practices can simultaneously reinforce and challenge the dominant (food) regime. We argue that current discussions on degrowth fail to envision how such contrasting developments are linked, and that the degrowth paradox originates in the idea of capitalism and the steady-state economy as alternative systems. The paradox dissolves with studies of mechanisms and social practices that show how the two systems are not autonomous, but ‘hybridised’ and come into existence and gain shape as reactions to each other.

KEYWORDS

Degrowth, social mechanisms, food relocalisation

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1. INTRODUCTION – THE DEGROWTH PARADOX

‘Towards what ultimate point is society tending by its industrial progress? When the progress ceases, in what condition are we to expect that it will leave mankind? It must always have been seen, more or less distinctly, by political economists, that the increase of wealth is not boundless: that at the end of what they term the progressive state lies the stationary state, that all progress in wealth is but a postponement of this, and that each step in advance is an approach to it.’ (Mill 2004 [1848]: 688)

The financial and economic turmoil of recent times on top of the ever-present environmental problems has invigorated old doubts about the deep-seated idea that prosperity depends on economic growth. The underlying question is quite straightforward: why do we want economic growth if it leads not only to environmental degradation, climate change, depletion of resources, but also to inequity, disparity in wealth and social injustice? Still, behind this obvious but difficult question lies an even thornier one: what exactly is the alternative?

The recent idea of degrowth is becoming increasingly popular as a social and political discourse outlining an alternative for conventional economic growth. Degrowth is not a single and unified theory or thinking tradition but rather resembles what Lakatos (1970) has called a ‘research programme’; a collection of studies with the common objective to expose the impossibility of exponential economic growth in a finite world and to outline alternative trajectories for social development. Its contenders plead use of the current environmental and financial crises to fundamentally change not only our policies and technologies, but also the way we conventionally think about the development of our societies and ourselves.

The idea of degrowth sounds simple enough: to halt or slow down economic growth in order to bring economies back within an ‘ecological safe operating space’ (Rockström et al., 2009) and to amend the growing global inequity in wealth. The ultimate aim of degrowth is the so-called ‘steady state economy’ (Daly, 1991): an economy with a flow of materials and energy (‘social metabolism’ – see Fischer-Kowalski and Haberl, 2007) that is kept within ecological limits. It is believed that the shrinkage of the global economy will almost automatically also result in a more equal distribution of wealth. But, cancelling out economic growth has radical consequences which raises questions about the practical feasibility of the degrowth proposal.

Degrowth is radical because it wants the end of capitalism. By singling out economic growth as the cause of ecological and social misery, degrowth blames the inner workings and logic of capitalism, since economic growth is the single mechanism that holds the capitalist economic system together. Consequently, any policy or movement that aims to halt growth is incompatible with capitalism, since capitalism with no growth is simply ‘an oxymoron’

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(Magdoff and Foster, 2010: 8). By maintaining that capitalism itself can never respect ecological limits, degrowth leaves no room for proposals for ‘green’ or ‘natural’ capitalism (Hawken et al., 1999; Barber, 2009; Greider, 2004) or ‘ecological modernisation’ (Young, 2000; Mol et al., 2009). These latter proposals typically include energy efficient technologies; new energy sources (e.g. nuclear power, coal, renewable energy); engineering solutions (e.g. geo-engineering, terraforming); and economic discounting for ecological services and costs (e.g. via cap and trade schemes) (Magdoff and Foster, 2010). All such proposals cease to be an option when what is needed is a complete transition to a post-capitalistic society.

For social scientists (as we are) the complete break with capitalism that is implied in the idea of degrowth constitutes something of a paradox, since it is a classic sociological insight that societies never start with a blank slate. Despite all the fundamental differences between *gemeinschaft* and *gesellschaft* (Tönnies); *mechanic* and *organic* solidarity (Durkheim); or *aristocracy* and *democracy* (de Tocqueville) the second half of these dichotomies always, from necessity, originates *from within* the first. It means that the new social order is already present in the old one – *in nuce*, as Engels phrased it (Engels, 1987 [1883]: 482). So, how does this sociological insight apply to degrowth if its proponents believe that a post-growth society cannot be shaped from within capitalism?

Solving this apparent paradox is the objective of this paper. We aim to answer the question if and how a process of degrowth can materialise from within capitalism with the help of some classic and more recent ideas and concepts from sociology. So far sociological insights and ideas have been remarkably absent from the scientific discussion about degrowth, the abandonment of capitalism, and the establishment of a steady-state economy. This is unfortunate since old as well as new sociological ideas can help to structure thinking about the many possible and impossible ways in which degrowth can develop.

This paper consists of three parts. It starts with defining degrowth and how its underlying ideas amount to the paradox just introduced. The second part introduces ideas and insights from both classical and contemporary sociology to solve this paradox. These are used in the third part of this paper to analyse the development of current food production and consumption. Based on this attempt we argue in the conclusion that social practices are ‘hybridised’. It is this hybridity that can potentially allow processes of degrowth to develop from *within* capitalism.

2. WHAT IS DEGROWTH?

‘An equitable downscaling of production and consumption that increases human well-being and enhances ecological conditions.’ This is how Schneider,

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Kallis and Martinez-Allier (2010) define degrowth. They add that downscaling reduces ‘the collective capacity to acquire and use physical resources’ (Schneider et al., 2010: 512), which is supposed to increase human wellbeing, equity and sustainability. Through a process of degrowth it becomes possible to transform our economies in such a way that we produce and consume less (Martinez-Allier et al., 2010). Degrowth does not mean non-growth or a stand-still of the whole economy (Latouche, 2010: 521; Kallis, 2011: 874).¹ Instead, it means limiting the flow of materials and energy to levels that fall within ecological limits, a so-called ‘steady state’ (Daly, 1991). Degrowth is needed to bring economic growth within these limits (see figure 1).

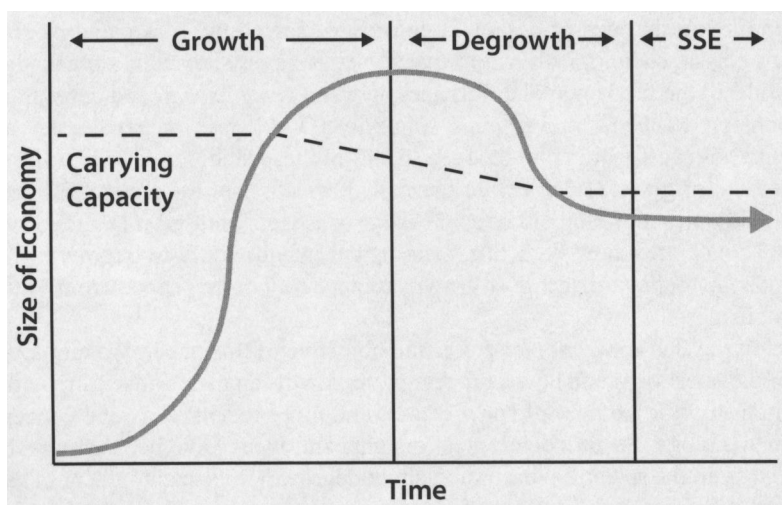


Figure 1. The degrowth transition to a steady state economy. SSE stands for Steady-State Economy (from O'Neill 2011, 2).

Degrowth is different from conventional ideas about sustainable development because its proponents argue that the global economy needs to relocalise and de-accelerate. To put it in economic terms: the GDP needs to decrease, which means that economies will shrink. If not, non-renewable energy and other natural resources will become depleted, causing all kinds of negative effects (crisis, collapse, poverty, etc.) (Spangenberg, 2010). The objective of degrowth is to prevent all that from happening through a conscious and radical

1. Consequently, some economic sectors, e.g. renewable energies or communal transport, might still be allowed to grow during a process of degrowth. Degrowth is thus selective (Latouche, 2010), which invokes some difficult questions about how one decides which sectors need to degrow and which ones are allowed to grow. It is the issue of limited or selective growth that divides the degrowth thinkers from the more Marxist-oriented political ecologists. The latter feel that allowing selective growth runs the risk of smuggling capitalism in through the backdoor (Foster, 2011).

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transformation of not only material metabolism (or ‘throughput’), but also of our economies, governance structures and even moral and spiritual reasoning (Ophuls, 2011).

Proponents of degrowth do not consider technological innovation as a solution for current and future crises, since technological fixes and efficiency improvements paradoxically increase rather than decrease consumption levels. This phenomenon is also known as the ‘Jevons paradox’ (Alcott, 2005). More generally, they argue that capitalism has to be abandoned altogether to allow a process of degrowth to take off.

On the one hand, arguments for degrowth are based on the conviction that degrowth cannot be realised within a capitalist system. Economic growth is imperative for the functioning of capitalism because it is structured towards a continuous search for economic growth, expansion and accumulation (Harvey, 2007). When growth stops capitalism stops and ‘the edifice [i.e. the capitalist system] starts trembling. Debts cannot be paid, credit runs out and unemployment sky-rockets’ (Kallis, 2011: 875). Realising the intimate connection between capitalism and growth leads to two implications. The first is that for a ‘prosperous’ process of degrowth (Odum and Odum 2001) – avoiding the massive debts, unemployment and social upheaval implicated in capitalism’s collapse – alternatives to capitalism need to be available and preferably ‘up and running’. On the other hand, leaving capitalism to its own devices, i.e. not doing anything, will inevitably not only lead to ecological collapse, but will also slowly erode the social and moral fabric that is desperately needed for any viable alternative society. So, there is urgency to act, but how? Or, to repeat the leading question of this paper, how can processes of degrowth materialise from within capitalism?

The literature on degrowth deals with this question from various angles. Concretely it proposes several policy reforms such as reduction in working hours (Victor, 2010), the implementation of a basic income (Raventós, 2007), limits on salaries (Latouche, 2010), and labour policies which prioritise employment in health and education sectors (Jackson, 2009). On a more general level it argues for a relocalisation and down-scaling of economies, which means that local economies are made more self-reliant and reduce their throughput via e.g. the introduction of local currencies (Seyfang, 2001) and the decentralisation of banks (Korten, 2008) and governance institutions (Fournier, 2008).

Several critics find it unrealistic to presume that people will voluntarily give up part of their income and their comfortable life styles (van den Bergh, 2011). In a response to this charge Kallis (2011) has raised some intriguing thoughts on how a degrowth transition could possibly take place. Referring to theories of ‘punctuated equilibrium’ and ‘threshold effects’ he postulates that overall social transformation can start from small beginnings: ‘mobilisations start with a new cultural story, initially a conversation among a few, that gradually comes to challenge an established paradigm that seemed previously unmovable. In

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the gap and loss of meaning created by a crisis, such new stories may seem to offer more convincing explanations and directions for action. Small, but accumulating, actions stemming from the initial conversations create gradually a new reality and give a concrete expression to the benefits of a different way of doing things. The new cultural story and the alternative, liberated social spaces and practices that embody it connect disparate people across interests and generate a social movement of thought and practice' (Kallis, 2011: 878).

Kallis' idea that societal transition and transformation occurs from bottom-up social practices is not new. There is considerable agreement among social scientists that this type of movement has a crucial role to play, not only as a force that keeps unbridled capitalism in check, but also as a platform from where people can adapt and transform. The groups of people making up these movements produce and reproduce an alternative set of knowledge, skills, income and services that not only allow a (temporal) 'escape' from capitalism, they can also help to facilitate changes in times of crisis. Olsson et al., for example, use the notions of 'shadow networks' and 'opportunity window' to point out the potential of networks that are politically independent and located 'outside the fray of regulation and implementation' (Olsson et al., 2006: 12). They can potentially come to function as 'incubators' for new solutions; since the members of shadow networks work *outside* the dominant system. In a similar vein, scholars working with so-called 'transition management' (TM) argue that a system transformation, or a transition, is needed to move towards a more sustainable society (Rotmans et al., 2001). Transitions are processes whereby a system suddenly shifts from one dynamic equilibrium to another dynamic equilibrium. TM scholars distinguish different levels and phases within such a transition (Geels and Kemp, 2000). There is a pre-development phase with no system level change, but innovation and experimentation at individual levels, or so-called 'niches'. This phase is followed by a take-off phase in which several of these innovations are taken up by others and diffuse in the different 'regimes' of the system. After take-off comes an acceleration phase which changes the 'socio-technical landscape'. The transition is concluded by a stabilisation phase in which a new equilibrium is reached. As the name TM indicates these scholars believe that, although transition processes can never be completely controlled, they can nevertheless be managed.²

What these approaches envision is a process of complex system change that is premised upon the basic mechanisms of Darwinian evolution: variation, selection and heredity. These are useful insights because they provide some first clues for unravelling the paradox that was introduced earlier. Variation

2. The argument that transitions can be managed has raised some debate. Shove and Walker (2007; 2008) not only question the possibilities for intervention that TM outlines, they also point out that TM too easily sidesteps issues of power and politics that are involved in transition management. TM scholars replied to this critique (Rotmans and Kemp 2008), but also started to investigate the power dynamics involved in socio-technical transitions and innovation (Avelino and Rotmans, 2011).

means that capitalism is never completely hegemonic; there will always be activities and processes that divert from dominant development. This ‘under-current’ and ‘diversions’ can potentially restructure dominant development through contingent or planned selection and successful heredity. The comparison with evolution also points out that the transition from capitalism to degrowth and to a steady-state economy is complex and therefore develops *relatively autonomously* from human action. But there is also need for some caution here. The system-lens of these approaches can easily invoke reification and functionalist thinking, i.e. treating systems as if they have needs and objectives, and to use these to explain the features of processes of societal stability and change. Furthermore, the Darwinian mechanisms operate differently in societies. Heredity of systemic features is not produced genetically but culturally, i.e. habits, norms or institutions are inherited through (both reflective and unreflective) learning and imitation and not faithfully copied as with genes. And there are, besides these three mechanisms, also other mechanisms at work, which do not have counterparts in Darwinian evolution. It is on these points of caution that recent social science can contribute.

3. UNDERSTANDING PROCESSES OF CHANGE THROUGH SOCIAL MECHANISMS

Theories of ‘punctuated equilibrium’, such as the examples above, usefully highlight that social processes feature different types of phases. Many (classical) sociologists often identify a relatively long phase of structural persistence with only incremental changes, and a relatively short phase of abrupt change transforming society, or fundamentally redirecting social trajectories.³ This distinction goes all the way back to Auguste Comte’s distinction between social statics and social dynamics, but can also be recognised in Karl Marx’s ideas about modes and relations of production that transform through social revolutions. A leading social scientific question remains how these phases of stability and transformation are produced

It is commonly assumed that macro-historical processes of social change are constituted by a connected sequence of lower-level causal mechanisms (Tilly and Goodin, 2006; Hedström and Udehn, 2009). Mahoney (2000: 517), for example, argues that it is possible to identify the mechanisms that stabilise certain social processes. Stabilising mechanisms produce positive feedback. ‘Each step along a particular path produces consequences, which make that path more attractive for the next round. As such effects begin to accumulate, they generate a powerful virtuous (or vicious) cycle of self-reinforcing activity’ (Pierson, 2000: 253).

3. See e.g. the collection of studies and graphs in Galtung and Inayatullah (1997), but also more recent studies on path dependency (e.g. Mahoney, 2000).

Early social scientists often referred to three different types of social mechanisms that lend stability to social practices: a) mechanisms that mediate the relation between people and their environment (technological innovation and adoption); b) mechanisms that mediate the relation among people (institutionalisation); and c) mechanisms that mediate the relation between people and their individual emotions, passions, interests and perceptions (identity formation). In short: technological, institutional and cognitive mechanisms. Take for example a footnote of Marx in *Capital* to which Harvey recently drew attention (Harvey, 2010: 189). 'Technology reveals the active relation of man to nature, the direct process of the production of his life, and thereby it also lays bare the process of the production of the social relations of his life, and of the mental conceptions that flow from those relations' (Marx, 1990 [1867] cited in Harvey, 2010: 191–192). Harvey argues that this elusive footnote contains all the elements that make up the general framework for Marx' dialectical and historical materialism. 'What Marx is saying [...] is that technologies and organizational forms internalize a certain relation to nature as well as to mental conceptions and social relations, daily life and labor processes. [...] All these elements constitute a totality, and we have to understand how the mutual interactions between them work' (Harvey, 2010: 193). Later social scientists, such as Norbert Elias or Charles Tilly, have used a similar distinction to explain the structural persistence of certain social practices. Elias, in his book *What is Sociology* (1978: 156), argues that structures in long-term processes of social change stem from the interdependencies, that exist between technological, institutional (or social), and psychological change. This *verflechtungsmechanismus*, as he originally called it, produces the direction or pattern of macro-historical processes of change. In other words, it is this interdependency that constitutes more or less structurally persistent phases in macro-historical processes of change. The next step is to identify sources of change and transformation in this conceptual scheme.

A typical feature of processes of social change is that its structural persistence from positive feedback is never complete, i.e. it can always be changed. Two major sources that produce this indeterminism of social practices exist. First of all, social practices are a result of agency – i.e. intentional and conscious choices as well as routine habits which are more or less autonomous from structural conditions (Giddens, 1984). This means that conditions influence people's actions, but they do not prescribe the specific content of any thought or action. So, agency is a central force shaping outcomes of processes of social change, but it is always embedded in a historical process which poses limits to what can actually be done. The second source that creates indeterminism is that the collective outcomes of social action can never precisely be planned; they always result in unanticipated and unintended consequences (Merton, 1936). Foucault captured this insight in the following way: 'People

know what they do; they frequently know why they do what they do; but what they don't know is what what they do does' (Dreyfus and Rabinow, 1982: 187).

Agency and unanticipated collective outcomes makes analysis of social mechanisms provisional, as they are linked to specified conditions and outcomes (Mahoney, 2001; Gerring, 2010). Another way of putting it would be to say that social mechanisms contribute to 'sometimes true theory' (Stinchcombe, 1998: 267), i.e. they identify certain general, social mechanisms that explain the stability of social phenomena, but these mechanisms take place under certain specified circumstances.

4. FOOD

As theoretical discussions always run the risk of losing sight of the actual practices in social reality, we have chosen to apply these mechanisms in a concrete theme. In this section of the paper we briefly highlight how different mechanisms of the three types identified earlier – i.e. technological, institutional and cognitive – stabilise the development of modern food production and consumption. To be sure, the mechanisms that we highlight are by no means exclusive. They should be regarded as illustrations of a general pattern. We also show how the 'food regime' is circumvented and challenged by so-called 'food re-localisation'. The relocalisation of production and consumption of food is one of the central objectives in proposals for degrowth (see e.g. Latouche, 2010: 44).⁴ It literally means that food is produced in the place where it is consumed. Relocalisation is, however, not only a matter of geographical allocation. It refers to a process in which food production and consumption is 're-located' from globalised industrial food systems to personal networks (Hendrickson and Heffernan, 2002: 348). Some commentators argue that food production and consumption practices are gaining shape that can potentially accommodate a transition to a relocalised food system. Some consider these alternative food networks and practices as the 'seeds of transition' (Wiskerke and van der Ploeg, 2004); others are more pessimistic and notice that many of the new initiatives are being colonised by a persistent agro-industrial food regime (Wilson, 2001; Evans et al., 2002; Walford, 2003; Mather et al., 2006).

4. Latouche, for example, argues that degrowth proposals need to materialise in a so-called 'bioregion': a relatively coherent social-spatial unit, which maintains self-sufficiency and autonomy in its production and consumption of energy and food (Latouche, 2010: 44). In this new (localised) degrowth society people will consume less and therefore require a lower level of economic surplus to be produced. At the same time, however, more people will have to work to meet consumer demands due to the limits on the use of fossil fuels.

4.1 Mechanisms stabilising the food regime

Which mechanisms reinforce current trends towards mass production and consumption of food? Farm mechanisation as technological mechanism usefully illustrates the possible effects of technological innovation and change. Initially, farmers at time X adopt new technology to gain higher incomes, since the increase in production lowers the average cost per commodity – the mechanism of ‘economies of scale’. Extra profit evaporates, however, when other farmers also increase their output through mechanisation. General production output increases and prices fall. This means that farmers at time Y have to mechanise in order to stay in business, because widespread mechanisation of farm production results in a general rise in output and consequently in lower prices, which negatively influences farmers’ incomes. This process is vividly captured with the metaphor of the ‘agricultural treadmill’ (Schnaiberg, 1980; Ward, 1993; Levins and Cochrane, 1996). But there are more explanations for the persistence of the treadmill. Technology use is often subject to self-reinforcing tendencies because farmers (just as other people) consider prior investments when making decisions, and tend to stick with earlier choices because they do not want to lose the capital that they invested earlier (such as knowledge, social networks, labour, etc.) – the ‘sunk-costs effect’ (Janssen and Scheffer, 2004). Or, alternatively, perhaps a farmer at an earlier stage has started to use a high-yielding variety that ripens uniformly and can be harvested all at once. In order to enjoy the benefits of a uniform and all-at-once yield she needs to use modern harvesting technology. These are so-called ‘compatibility effects’ (van der Ploeg, 1991: 214–218; Scott, 1998: 267).

Mechanisation also structurally changes the institutional landscape in which food is produced and consumed. The introduction of modern scientific and industrial farming technologies transforms not only production processes on-farm, but also the ways in which farm production interlinks with a much wider and far-ranging set of technologies, institutions, networks and organisations for the mobilisation of off-farm resources (input) and the commercialisation of end-products (output). We want to highlight three central mechanisms here: *externalisation*, *standardisation* and *distantiation*. Externalisation refers to the process of outsourcing work that used to be performed on-farm to companies or persons off-farm. Standardisation refers to the process by which farm production is made more uniform across time and space through agreed-upon rules (Timmermans and Epstein, 2010). These standards regarding farm input and output allow the creation of synergy between a number of heterogeneous farms and agribusinesses. Mass industrial processing can only function if it receives a relatively homogenous raw product. The rise of agribusiness also propels the mechanism of distantiation, which refers to the growing spatial and social separation between food consumption and production. Simply put, farmers specialise in the production of raw products, while agribusiness

process these products. It means that farmers stop processing their own products, and that the on-farm sale of consumer products mostly disappears.

It is suggested that the persistence of a 'productivist' outlook of the majority of European farmers is a result of the adaptation of preferences towards an opportunity context that is shaped by the mechanisms associated with the modernisation of food production that we just highlighted (Frouws and Benvenuti, 1998; Wilson, 2001). Recent studies on farmers' self-identities affirm this hypothesis. Burton and Wilson (2006) have conceptualised a 'productivist farmer identity role', which includes 'increasing reliance on, and intensification of, agriculture, and a degree of faith in technocentric approaches to land management' (Burton and Wilson, 2006: 101). Studies show that farmers who identify themselves as productivist associate a diverse landscape that is rich in biodiversity with poor farming practices and laziness. These farmers associate tidy and ordered farm landscapes with straight rows and without weeds with hard work and progress (Burton, 2004).

The above changes also have profound consequences for the ways in which people consume food. First of all, food products have become increasingly differentiated, through the mechanism of *specialisation*, i.e. 'the subdivision of previously unified activities or singular products' (Shove and Warde, 2001: 11). Agribusiness widened the range of consumer products and tailored products to specific activities. The different types of milk currently on offer in regular European supermarkets can serve as example, e.g. café latte milk, flavoured milk, non-homogenised milk, local milk, local ecological milk. At the same time, food products are also standardised. Mechanisms that sustain standardisation and homogenisation are, amongst others, the *grading* of products, *standard manufacturing* or the creation of *legal standards* (Carruthers and Stinchcombe, 1999). Through these mechanisms people are enabled to find the same type of food products irrespective of time and place, which means that people become used to eating their preferred diet anywhere and anytime and has the effect of locking households 'into particular ways of reproducing themselves on a daily basis' (Shove and Warde, 2001: 238).

4.2 Food relocation

As we pointed out, the stability of regimes is always conditional; regimes can always unsettle due to people's agency and the unforeseen consequences of their social interaction. Several rural sociologists have highlighted practices of food production and consumption that can potentially trigger such a 'regime shift'. These types of practices are often labelled as 'post-productivist' or 'multifunctional' and include a wide range of production and consumption activities. Studies of farm production show that farmers can escape the agricultural treadmill through reducing costs, working off-farm, diversifying farm production or adding value to farm products (e.g. van der Ploeg and Roep,

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2003; Wiskerke and van der Ploeg, 2004). With these activities farmers cope not only with structurally decreasing economic margins (profit squeeze), but act upon changing consumer demands and the growing importance of public goods, i.e. rural landscapes and ecological biodiversity. These 'multifunctional' or 'postproductivist' farms differ from conventional ('productivist') farming not only in the technology they use but also in their institutional embeddedness, because they actively transform the on-farm production of commodities (e.g. raw products) and non-commodities (e.g. environmental services, landscape amenities, cultural heritage). When it comes to changes in cognition, research has also identified a 'post-productivist' farmer identity – in contrast to a 'productivist' farmer identity – which stresses 'a lesser role for agriculture (yet perhaps not peripheral), an increased consideration of environmental factors, and a diversity of approaches to land management' (Burton and Wilson, 2006: 101).

Similar trends can also be witnessed in consumption. For some groups of consumers the buying and eating of food that is mass-produced creates feelings that they have no control over the effects of their consumption choices. These feelings can trigger an interest in a re-located consumption, which is physically re-located in their immediate ecological and social context. Proximity and direct interaction with producers are preferred over interaction with a globalised food system. A mechanism that can be used to describe the origin of these feelings is 'cognitive disequilibrium'. This means that a person's views or habits are challenged through new information. People's reactions on cognitive disequilibrium can range from changing consumption (*accommodation*) to re-interpreting information as to make it fit initial views and habits (*assimilation*). Good examples of events that can trigger such changes are crises related to food safety (e.g. BSE).

4.3. *Food for thought*

In the above paragraphs we highlighted some mechanisms that help to explain the stability of the current food regime that is based on mass production and consumption. It also highlighted practices of food production and consumption that go against this self-reinforcing trend. Often food relocation is juxtaposed with conventional practices of food production and consumption, which produces an image of a divided world (Goodman et al., 2011). The people, their identities, technologies and institutions that are involved in the regime of mass food production cannot be found in the alternative, resistant practices of food relocalisation. 'East is east, and west is west, and never the twain shall meet' (see also Wilson, 2001; Evans et al., 2002; Walford, 2003; Mather et al., 2006 for similar remarks on 'productivism' and 'post-productivism'). The discussion then reinforces this dichotomy: do new ways of food production and consumption signal a break with capitalist consumption patterns, or are they

just a reinforcement of old habits albeit with some uncontroversial changes? The parallel with the degrowth paradox that we introduced earlier is apparent. In both discussions it becomes difficult to envision how such contrasting developments can possibly be linked.

The point that is missed in such discussions is that the reality of making and eating food is more often than not characterised by a 'hybridity' (Latour, 2007). What people produce and consume is not limited exclusively to part of the dominant food regime, or of food relocalisation. Instead, people, as 'bricoleurs' (Levi-Strauss, 1966 [1962]), routinely sell and buy food in a regime that is rapidly becoming more and more complex and self-contradictory. This idea is also reflected in Gibson-Graham's 'diverse economy approach' (2006), which recently has become very influential in food research. Gibson-Graham understands the current social system as being composed of a myriad of capitalist, alternative capitalist and non-capitalist relations.⁵ With their anti-essentialist approach to capitalism they focus on the diversity in economic organisation and on how this is articulated in people's everyday actions. In a similar vein, Watts et al. (2005) distinguishes different networks in local food economies and state these are not exclusive. Individual producers are often engaged in more than one network (Buller, 2003 in Watts et al., 2005), which is why they call for future research that considers food production systems as 'hybridized when considered at the level of the individual enterprise' (Watts et al., 2005: 35).

The co-existence of conventional food production and consumption with ideas and practices more related to food relocalisation can usefully be illustrated with recent research on European farmers' identities and farm practices. These studies indicate that although productivist preferences are generally persistent, farmers generally do not experience a very strict difference between productivist and post-productivist views and attitudes (Wilson, 2001; Wilson and Hart, 2000; Burton and Wilson, 2006). Often farmers combine an intensive production process with different types of post-productivist activities. For example, farmers combine participation in agri-environmental schemes routinely with very conventional farming styles (e.g. large-scale monoculture). The majority of these farmers diversify primarily for financial reasons, and because the diversification does not disrupt or impact existing conventional farm management practices (Wilson and Hart, 2000). Even more so, Winter and Gaskell (1998) argue that participation in environmental schemes often helps farmers to continue food production as usual. In other words, opportunities related to diversification (e.g. subsidies related to participation in environmental

5. Gibson-Graham's investigation is explicitly also a political project. They argue that a central objective of their research is to overcome the 'dampening and discouraging effect' (Gibson-Graham, 2008: 618) of the representation of capitalism as an all-encompassing system, since unsettling such powerful representations make the envisioning of an alternative society and alternative economic projects more likely.

schemes, or local food networks) co-evolve with conventional scale enlargement and intensification of food production. They can even finance and sustain industrialised food production regimes and in so doing block or hamper a transition to relocalised food production.

Similar attitudes can be witnessed in food consumption. Most consumers (even 'moral' or 'green' consumers) do not radically break with the capitalist economy. People often have one foot in a capitalist economy, and the other foot in an urban garden or buying club. And this interpretation probably also holds for many other people who are involved in other parts of the global food movement. Paraphrasing Scott (1985) some of these people might 'reluctantly comply' with capitalism. Others, however, are far less reflective about the structures that govern us and just enjoy growing their own food.

These findings confirm that the key to social transition lies in the inherent variety of social life. A variety produced through people's agency and the contingent and unexpected outcomes of social interaction. We prefer to use the word 'hybridity' instead of diversity in order not to misconceive variety as the existence of radically different systems. Such a conception precisely creates the paradox that we aim to solve. Conceptualising systems as hybrids allows us instead to explain how structurally persistent social practices can produce new social practices that can potentially cause major social change. To be sure, acknowledging hybridity does not imply that anything goes. Hybridity can never be the sole trigger of social transformation, but is always produced from the structural persistence of technological, institutional and cognitive mechanisms. So, indeed, the present always contains a new starting point, but it never starts with a blank slate. Triggers only work when 'the time is right'.

5. THE REVOLUTIONARY MOMENT

Based on the argument presented here, we argue that the degrowth paradox originates in the idea of capitalism and the steady-state economy as alternative systems. It dissolves with studies of social practices that show how the two systems are not completely autonomous, but often gain shape and come into existence as reactions to each other. These everyday practices are the result of agency, i.e. intentional and conscious choices as well as routine habits and may be more or less relatively autonomous from structural conditions (Giddens, 1984). Thus, agency is a central force shaping outcomes of processes of social change, but to stop here would create a new fallacy, since it would make social change inherently contingent and structureless. Therefore we argue that to really solve the paradox, capitalism and the steady-state economy should be considered as phases or regimes that describe the same system, albeit at different points in time. Social practices are always embedded in a historical process, which poses limits to what can actually be done. It means that current

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regimes, whether capitalism or the current food regime, are not hegemonic, and that their structural persistence can be broken down, but not just as people please.

Understanding the dynamics of social change in general, and the prospect of degrowth in particular, requires a careful analysis of the technological, institutional and cognitive mechanisms that reinforce social regimes, as well as those social practices that can potentially undermine their stability. When regimes are structurally persistent these mechanisms will be strong. Sooner or later, however, this phase will produce opportunities for alternative trajectories to grow and which can shape conditions in which the dominant regime (often quickly and abruptly) breaks down. This is how we think it works. When it works? We dare not say.

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